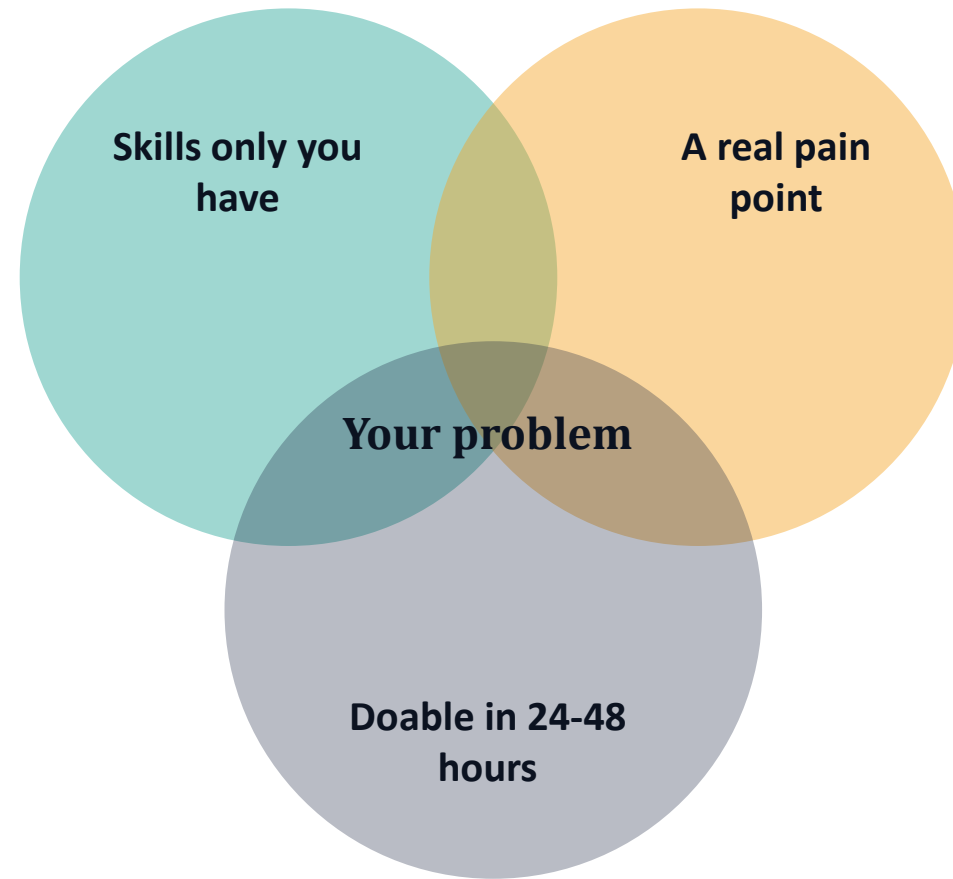


HACKATHON SPEAKER SESSION

Hacking the Hackathon: Playbook for Winning & Beyond

Tips, tricks and mindset from an industry for rapid prototyping, high-impact pitching, and career acceleration.

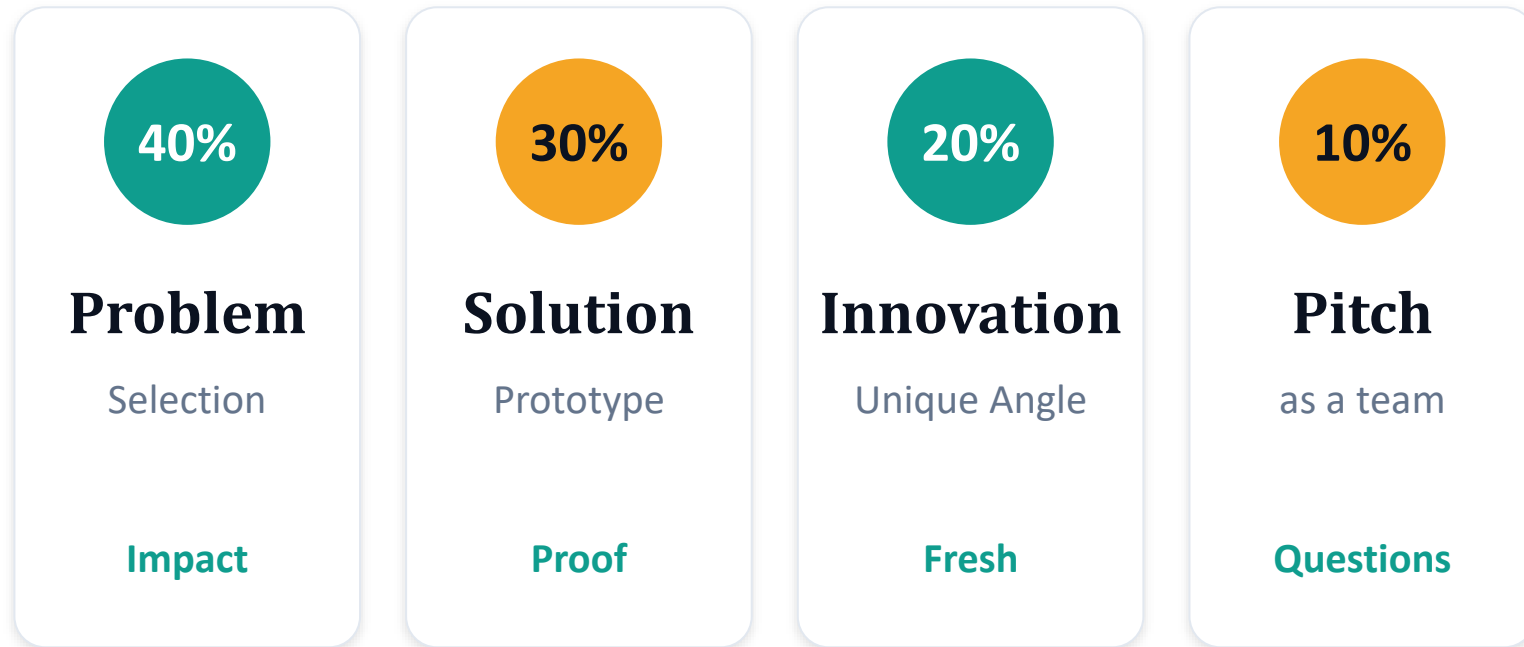
Pick where your skills are unfair



Five questions before you commit

- 1 Who exactly has this problem? (one person, not 'everyone')
- 2 Can I state it in one sentence?
- 3 How do they solve it today, and why is that painful?
- 4 Can I demo the fix in under 3 minutes?
- 5 Do I have the data or APIs I need right now?

Decoding Evaluation Secret



EXECUTION STRATEGY

Scoping for Maximum Impact

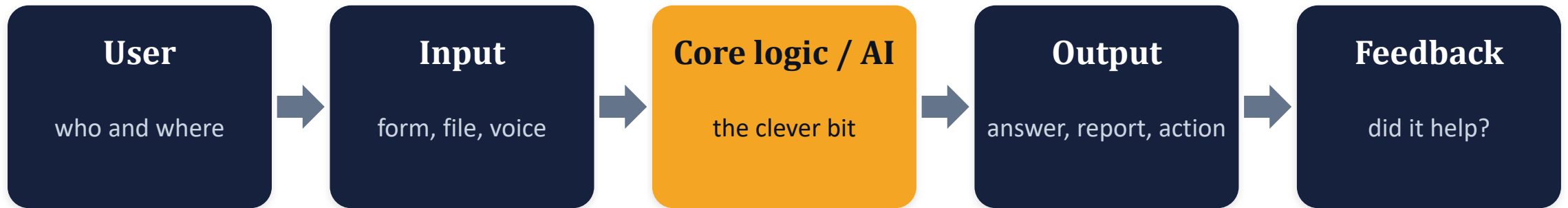
✓ Winning MVP Focus

- ✓ **Single Hero Feature:** Perfect execution on 1 key action.
- ✓ **Mocked Edge Cases:** Hardcoded non-essential pathways.
- ✓ **Flawless Happy Path:** Zero bugs during main pitch demo.

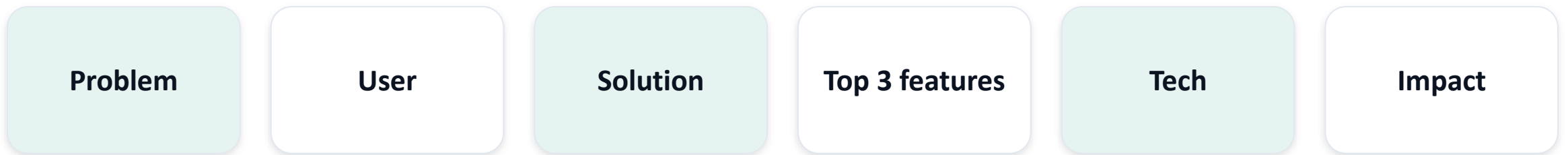
⚠ Common Rookie Pitfall

- ✗ **Feature Overload:** 5 unpolished incomplete features.
- ✗ **Auth Obstacle:** Spending hours on user login screens.
- ✗ **Broken Demos:** Crashing on stage due to edge bugs.

Sketch the solution on one page



Your one-page solution canvas



WHEN IT GETS HARD

**Hour 14 is where
most teams quit.
That is your edge.**

*You do not need to be the strongest coder in
the room. Be the clearest thinker.*

Shrink the problem

Cut scope until it works, then add back.

Ask for help

Mentors are there for exactly this moment.

Ship the ugly version

Progress beats polish at 3 AM.

The 3-minute pitch, second by second

Hook 0:30	Who and why 0:30	Live demo 1:15	How it works 0:30	Ask 0:15
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Open with a person

Start with one human story, not a tech stack.

Demo the happy path

Skip edge cases. Keep a recorded backup ready.

End with one ask

Feedback, a pilot, a mentor: make it specific.

Flawless Live Demo Principles

Pre-record Backup Video

Always capture a clean screen recording before final submission.

Show Value in 30 Seconds

Jump straight into functional output; skip onboarding forms.

Stick to Scripted Path

Never attempt unscripted feature testing in front of judges.



QUESTIONS?

Now build something worth
demoing.

Thank you | Sree Keerthana



Sree Keerthana

Top 1% Topmate 🏆 SWE Global Ambassador
🌐 Technical Business Analyst 📁 12+ Years in e...

